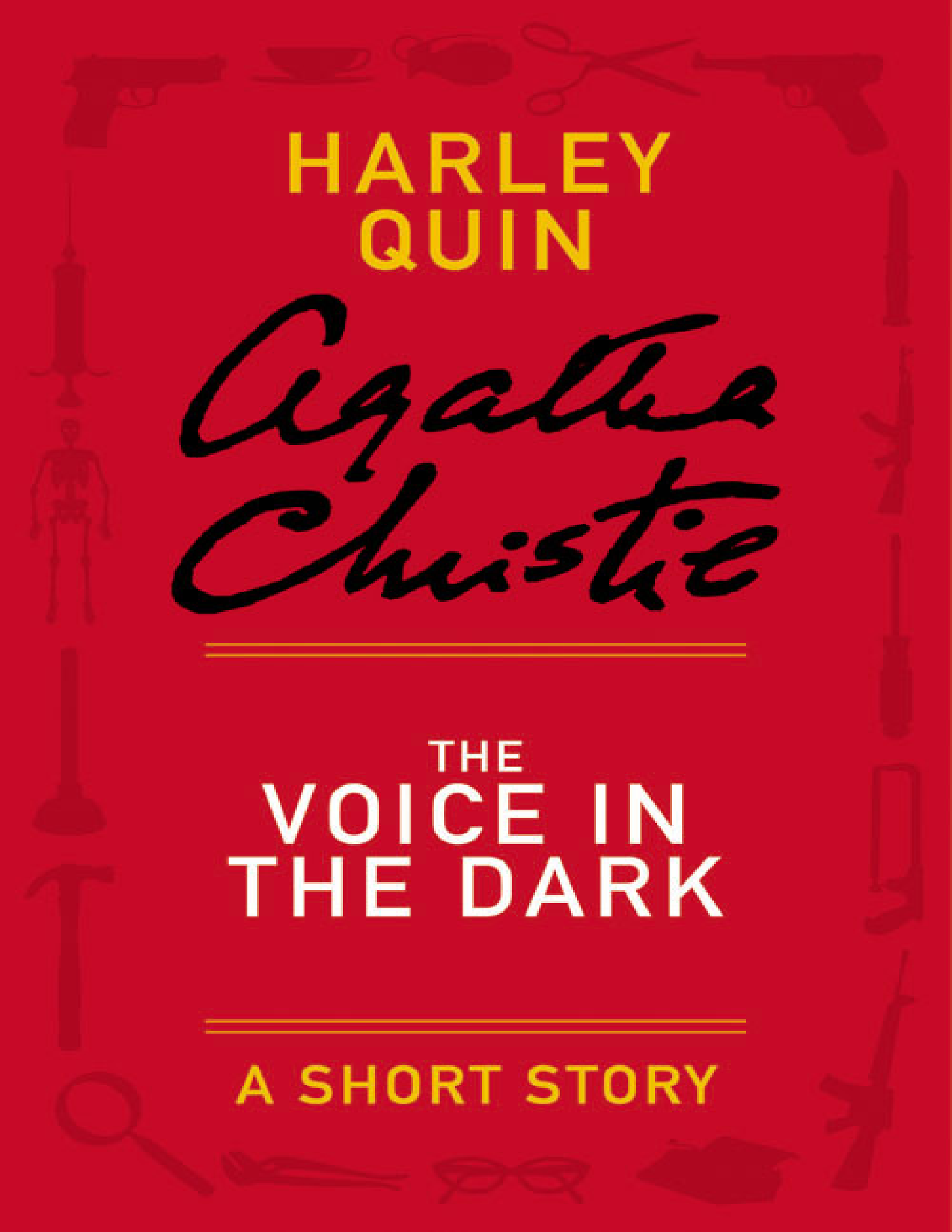




HARLEY
QUIN

*Agatha
Christie*

THE
VOICE IN
THE DARK

A SHORT STORY

The Voice in the Dark

A Short Story

Agatha Christie

WITNESS
IMPULSE

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THE VOICE IN THE DARK

I am a little worried about Margery,” said Lady Stranleigh.

“My girl, you know,” she added.

She sighed pensively.

“It makes one feel terribly old to have a grown-up daughter.”

Mr. Satterthwaite, who was the recipient of these confidences, rose to the occasion gallantly.

“No one could believe it possible,” he declared with a little bow.

“Flatterer,” said Lady Stranleigh, but she said it vaguely and it was clear that her mind was elsewhere.

Mr. Satterthwaite looked at the slender white-clad figure in some admiration. The Cannes sunshine was searching, but Lady Stranleigh came through the test very well. At a distance the youthful effect was really extraordinary. One almost wondered if she were grown-up or not. Mr. Satterthwaite, who knew everything, knew that it was perfectly possible for Lady Stranleigh to have grown-up grandchildren. She represented the extreme triumph of art over nature. Her figure was marvellous, her complexion was marvellous. She had enriched many beauty parlours and certainly the results were astounding.

Lady Stranleigh lit a cigarette, crossed her beautiful legs encased in the finest of nude silk stockings and murmured: “Yes, I really am rather worried about Margery.”

“Dear me,” said Mr. Satterthwaite, “what is the trouble?”

Lady Stranleigh turned her beautiful blue eyes upon him.

“You have never met her, have you? She is Charles’ daughter,” she added helpfully.

If entries in ‘Who’s Who’ were strictly truthful, the entries concerning Lady Stranleigh might have ended as follows: *hobbies: getting married.*

She had floated through life shedding husbands as she went. She had lost three by divorce and one by death.

“If she had been Rudolph’s child I could have understood it,” mused Lady Stranleigh. “You remember Rudolf? He was always temperamental. Six months after we married I had to apply for those queer things—what do they call them? Conjugal what nots, you know what I mean. Thank goodness it is all much simpler nowadays. I remember I had to write him the silliest kind of letter—my lawyer practically dictated it to me. Asking him to come back, you know, and that I would do all I could, etc., etc., but you never could count on Rudolf, he was so temperamental. He came rushing home at once, which was quite the wrong thing to do, and not at all what the lawyers meant.”

She sighed.

“About Margery?” suggested Mr. Satterthwaite, tactfully leading her back to the subject under discussion.

“Of course. I was just going to tell you, wasn’t I? Margery has been seeing things, or hearing them. Ghosts, you know, and all that. I should never have thought that Margery could be so imaginative. She is a dear good girl, always has been, but just a shade—dull.”

“Impossible,” murmured Mr. Satterthwaite with a confused idea of being complimentary.

“In fact, very dull,” said Lady Stranleigh. “Doesn’t care for dancing, or cocktails or any of the things a young girl ought to care about. She much prefers staying at home to hunt instead of coming out here with me.”

“Dear, dear,” said Mr. Satterthwaite, “she wouldn’t come out with you, you say?”

“Well, I didn’t exactly press her. Daughters have a depressing effect upon one, I find.”

Mr. Satterthwaite tried to think of Lady Stranleigh accompanied by a serious-minded daughter and failed.

“I can’t help wondering if Margery is going off her head,” continued Margery’s mother in a cheerful voice. “Hearing voices is a very bad sign, so they tell me. It is not as though Abbot’s Mede were haunted. The old building was burnt to the ground in 1836, and they put up a kind of early Victorian château which simply cannot be haunted. It is much too ugly and commonplace.”

Mr. Satterthwaite coughed. He was wondering why he was being told all this.

"I thought perhaps," said Lady Stranleigh, smiling brilliantly upon him, "that *you* might be able to help me."

"I?"

"Yes. You are going back to England tomorrow, aren't you?"

"I am. Yes, that is so," admitted Mr. Satterthwaite cautiously.

"And you know all these psychical research people. Of course you do, you know everybody."

Mr. Satterthwaite smiled a little. It was one of his weaknesses to know everybody.

"So what can be simpler?" continued Lady Stranleigh. "I never get on with that sort of person. You know—earnest men with beards and usually spectacles. They bore me terribly and I am quite at my worst with them."

Mr. Satterthwaite was rather taken aback. Lady Stranleigh continued to smile at him brilliantly.

"So that is all settled, isn't it?" she said brightly. "You will go down to Abbot's Mede and see Margery, and make all the arrangements. I shall be terribly grateful to you. Of course if Margery is *really* going off her head, I will come home. Ah! Here is Bimbo."

Her smile from being brilliant became dazzling.

A young man in white tennis flannels was approaching them. He was about twenty-five years of age and extremely good-looking.

The young man said simply:

"I have been looking for you everywhere, Babs."

"What has the tennis been like?"

"Septic."

Lady Stranleigh rose. She turned her head over her shoulder and murmured in dulcet tones to Mr. Satterthwaite: "It is simply marvellous of you to help me. I shall never forget it."

Mr. Satterthwaite looked after the retreating couple.

"I wonder," he mused to himself, "If Bimbo is going to be No. 5."

The conductor of the Train de Luxe was pointing out to Mr. Satterthwaite where an accident on the line had occurred a few years previously. As he

finished his spirited narrative, the other looked up and saw a well-known face smiling at him over the conductor's shoulder.

"My dear Mr. Quin," said Mr. Satterthwaite.

His little withered face broke into smiles.

"What a coincidence! That we should both be returning to England on the same train. You are going there, I suppose."

"Yes," said Mr. Quin. "I have business there of rather an important nature. Are you taking the first service of dinner?"

"I always do so. Of course, it is an absurd time—half-past six, but one runs less risk with the cooking."

Mr. Quin nodded comprehendingly.

"I also," he said. "We might perhaps arrange to sit together."

Half-past six found Mr. Quin and Mr. Satterthwaite established opposite each other at a small table in the dining car. Mr. Satterthwaite gave due attention to the wine list and then turned to his companion.

"I have not seen you since—ah, yes not since Corsica. You left very suddenly that day."

Mr. Quin shrugged his shoulders.

"Not more so than usual. I come and go, you know. I come and go."

The words seemed to awake some echo of remembrance in Mr. Satterthwaite's mind. A little shiver passed down his spine—not a disagreeable sensation, quite the contrary. He was conscious of a pleasurable sense of anticipation.

Mr. Quin was holding up a bottle of red wine, examining the label on it. The bottle was between him and the light but for a minute or two a red glow enveloped his person.

Mr. Satterthwaite felt again that sudden stir of excitement.

"I too have a kind of mission in England," he remarked, smiling broadly at the remembrance. "You know Lady Stranleigh perhaps?"

Mr. Quin shook his head.

"It is an old title," said Mr. Satterthwaite, "a very old title. One of the few that can descend in the female line. She is a Baroness in her own right. Rather a romantic history really."

Mr. Quin settled himself more comfortably in his chair. A waiter, flying down the swinging car, deposited cups of soup before them as if by a miracle. Mr. Quin sipped it cautiously.

“You are about to give me one of those wonderful descriptive portraits of yours,” he murmured, “that is so, is it not?”

Mr. Satterthwaite beamed on him.

“She is really a marvellous woman,” he said. “Sixty, you know—yes, I should say at least sixty. I knew them as girls, she and her sister. Beatrice, that was the name of the elder one. Beatrice and Barbara. I remember them as the Barron girls. Both good-looking and in those days very hard up. But that was a great many years ago—why, dear me, I was a young man myself then.” Mr. Satterthwaite sighed. “There were several lives then between them and the title. Old Lord Stranleigh was a first cousin once removed, I think. Lady Stranleigh’s life has been quite a romantic affair. Three unexpected deaths—two of the old man’s brothers and a nephew. Then there was the ‘Uralia.’ You remember the wreck of the ‘Uralia?’ She went down off the coast of New Zealand. The Barron girls were on board. Beatrice was drowned. This one, Barbara, was amongst the few survivors. Six months later, old Stranleigh died and she succeeded to the title and came into a considerable fortune. Since then she has lived for one thing only—herself! She has always been the same, beautiful, unscrupulous, completely callous, interested solely in herself. She has had four husbands, and I have no doubt could get a fifth in a minute.”

He went on to describe the mission with which he had been entrusted by Lady Stranleigh.

“I thought of running down to Abbot’s Mede to see the young lady,” he explained. “I—I feel that something ought to be done about the matter. It is impossible to think of Lady Stranleigh as an ordinary mother.” He stopped, looking across the table at Mr. Quin.

“I wish you would come with me,” he said wistfully. “Would it not be possible?”

“I’m afraid not,” said Mr. Quin. “But let me see, Abbot’s Mede is in Wiltshire, is it not?”

Mr. Satterthwaite nodded.

“I thought as much. As it happens, I shall be staying not far from Abbot’s Mede, at a place you and I both know.” He smiled. “You remember that little inn, the ‘Bells and Motley’?”

“Of course,” cried Mr. Satterthwaite; “you will be there?”

Mr. Quin nodded. "For a week or ten days. Possibly longer. If you will come and look me up one day, I shall be delighted to see you."

And somehow or other Mr. Satterthwaite felt strangely comforted by the assurance.

"My dear Miss—er—Margery," said Mr. Satterthwaite, "I assure you that I should not dream of laughing at you."

Margery Gale frowned a little. They were sitting in the large comfortable hall of Abbot's Mede. Margery Gale was a big squarely built girl. She bore no resemblance to her mother, but took entirely after her father's side of the family, a line of hard-riding country squires. She looked fresh and wholesome and the picture of sanity. Nevertheless, Mr. Satterthwaite was reflecting to himself that the Barrons as a family were all inclined to mental instability. Margery might have inherited her physical appearance from her father and at the same time have inherited some mental kink from her mother's side of the family.

"I wish," said Margery, "that I could get rid of that Casson woman. I don't believe in spiritualism, and I don't like it. She is one of these silly women that run a craze to death. She is always bothering me to have a medium down here."

Mr. Satterthwaite coughed, fidgeted a little in his chair and then said in a judicial manner:

"Let me be quite sure that I have all the facts. The first of the—er—phenomena occurred two months ago, I understand?"

"About that," agreed the girl. "Sometimes it was a whisper and sometimes it was quite a clear voice but it always said much the same thing."

"Which was?"

"*Give back what is not yours. Give back what you have stolen.* On each occasion I switched on the light, but the room was quite empty and there was no one there. In the end I got so nervous that I got Clayton, mother's maid, to sleep on the sofa in my room."

"And the voice came just the same?"

"Yes—and this is what frightens me—Clayton did not hear it."

Mr. Satterthwaite reflected for a minute or two.

"Did it come loudly or softly that evening?"

"It was almost a whisper," admitted Margery. "If Clayton was sound asleep I suppose she would not really have heard it. She wanted me to see a doctor." The girl laughed bitterly.

"But since last night even Clayton believes," she continued.

"What happened last night?"

"I am just going to tell you. I have told no one as yet. I had been out hunting yesterday and we had had a long run. I was dead tired, and slept very heavily. I dreamt—a horrible dream—that I had fallen over some iron railings and that one of the spikes was entering slowly into my throat. I woke to find that it was true—there was some sharp point pressing into the side of my neck, and at the same time a voice was murmuring softly: '*You have stolen what is mine. This is death.*'"

"I screamed," continued Margery, "and clutched at the air, but there was nothing there. Clayton heard me scream from the room next door where she was sleeping. She came rushing in, and she distinctly felt something brushing past her in the darkness, but she says that whatever that something was, it was not anything human."

Mr. Satterthwaite stared at her. The girl was obviously very shaken and upset. He noticed on the left side of her throat a small square of sticking plaster. She caught the direction of his gaze and nodded.

"Yes," she said, "it was not imagination, you see."

Mr. Satterthwaite put a question almost apologetically, it sounded so melodramatic.

"You don't know of anyone—er—who has a grudge against you?" he asked.

"Of course not," said Margery. "What an idea!"

Mr. Satterthwaite started on another line of attack.

"What visitors have you had during the last two months?"

"You don't mean just people for weekends, I suppose? Marcia Keane has been with me all along. She is my best friend, and just as keen on horses as I am. Then my cousin Roley Vavasour has been here a good deal."

Mr. Satterthwaite nodded. He suggested that he should see Clayton, the maid.

"She has been with you a long time, I suppose?" he asked.

"Donkey's years," said Margery. "She was Mother's and Aunt Beatrice's maid when they were girls. That is why Mother has kept her on, I

suppose, although she has got a French maid for herself. Clayton does sewing and pottering little odd jobs.”

She took him upstairs and presently Clayton came to them. She was a tall, thin, old woman, with grey hair neatly parted, and she looked the acme of respectability.

“No, sir,” she said in answer to Mr. Satterthwaite’s inquiries. “I have never heard anything of the house being haunted. To tell you the truth, sir, I thought it was all Miss Margery’s imagination until last night. But I actually felt something—brushing by me in the darkness. And I can tell you this, sir, *it was not anything human*. And then there is that wound in Miss Margery’s neck. She didn’t do that herself, poor lamb.”

But her words were suggestive to Mr. Satterthwaite. Was it possible that Margery could have inflicted that wound herself? He had heard of strange cases where girls apparently just as sane and well-balanced as Margery had done the most amazing things.

“It will soon heal up,” said Clayton. “It’s not like this scar of mine.”

She pointed to a mark on her own forehead.

“That was done forty years ago, sir; I still bear the mark of it.”

“It was the time the ‘Uralia’ went down,” put in Margery. “Clayton was hit on the head by a spar, weren’t you, Clayton?”

“Yes, Miss.”

“What do you think yourself, Clayton,” asked Mr. Satterthwaite, “what do you think was the meaning of this attack on Miss Margery?”

“I really should not like to say, sir.”

Mr. Satterthwaite read this correctly as the reserve of the well-trained servant.

“What do you really think, Clayton?” he said persuasively.

“I think, sir, that something very wicked must have been done in this house, and that until that is wiped out there won’t be any peace.”

The woman spoke gravely, and her faded blue eyes met his steadily.

Mr. Satterthwaite went downstairs rather disappointed. Clayton evidently held the orthodox view, a deliberate “haunting” as a consequence of some evil deed in the past. Mr. Satterthwaite himself was not so easily satisfied. The phenomena had only taken place in the last two months. Had only taken place since Marcia Keane and Roley Vavasour had been there. He must find out something about these two. It was possible that the whole

thing was a practical joke. But he shook his head, dissatisfied with that solution. The thing was more sinister than that. The post had just come in and Margery was opening and reading her letters. Suddenly she gave an exclamation.

“Mother is too absurd,” she said. “Do read this.” She handed the letter to Mr. Satterthwaite.

It was an epistle typical of Lady Stranleigh.

Darling Margery (she wrote),

I am so glad you have that nice little Mr. Satterthwaite there. He is awfully clever and knows all the big-wig spook people. You must have them all down and investigate things thoroughly. I am sure you will have a perfectly marvellous time, and I only wish I could be there, but I have really been quite ill the last few days. The hotels are so careless about the food they give one. The doctor says it is some kind of food poisoning. I was really very ill.

Sweet of you to send me the chocolates, darling, but surely just a wee bit silly, wasn't it? I mean, there's such wonderful confectionery out here.

Bye-bye, darling, and have a lovely time laying the family ghosts. Bimbo says my tennis is coming on marvellously. Oceans of love.

Yours,

Barbara.

“Mother always wants me to call her Barbara,” said Margery. “Simply silly, I think.”

Mr. Satterthwaite smiled a little. He realized that the stolid conservatism of her daughter must on occasions be very trying to Lady Stranleigh. The contents of her letter struck him in a way in which obviously they did not strike Margery.

“Did you send your mother a box of chocolates?” he asked.

Margery shook her head. “No, I didn't, it must have been someone else.”

Mr. Satterthwaite looked grave. Two things struck him as of significance. Lady Stranleigh had received a gift of a box of chocolates and she was suffering from a severe attack of poisoning. Apparently she had not connected these two things. Was there a connection? He himself was inclined to think there was.

A tall dark girl lounged out of the morning room and joined them.

She was introduced to Mr. Satterthwaite as Marcia Keane. She smiled on the little man in an easy good-humoured fashion.

“Have you come down to hunt Margery’s pet ghost?” she asked in a drawling voice. “We all rot her about that ghost. Hello, here’s Roley.”

A car had just drawn up at the front door. Out of it tumbled a tall young man with fair hair and an eager boyish manner.

“Hello, Margery,” he cried. “Hello, Marcia! I have brought down reinforcements.” He turned to the two women who were just entering the hall. Mr. Satterthwaite recognized in the first one of the two the Mrs. Casson of whom Margery had spoken just now.

“You must forgive me, Margery, dear,” she drawled, smiling broadly. “Mr. Vavasour told us that it would be quite all right. It was really his idea that I should bring down Mrs. Lloyd with me.”

She indicated her companion with a slight gesture of the hand.

“This is Mrs. Lloyd,” she said in a tone of triumph. “Simply the most wonderful medium that ever existed.”

Mrs. Lloyd uttered no modest protest, she bowed and remained with her hands crossed in front of her. She was a highly coloured young woman of commonplace appearance. Her clothes were unfashionable but rather ornate. She wore a chain of moonstones and several rings.

Margery Gale, as Mr. Satterthwaite could see, was not too pleased at this intrusion. She threw an angry look at Roley Vavasour, who seemed quite unconscious of the offence he had caused.

“Lunch is ready, I think,” said Margery.

“Good,” said Mrs. Casson. “We will hold a *séance* immediately afterwards. Have you got some fruit for Mrs. Lloyd? She never eats a solid meal before a *séance*.”

They all went into the dining room. The medium ate two bananas and an apple, and replied cautiously and briefly to the various polite remarks which

Margery addressed to her from time to time. Just before they rose from the table, she flung back her head suddenly and sniffed the air.

"There is something very wrong in this house. I feel it."

"Isn't she wonderful?" said Mrs. Casson in a low delighted voice.

"Oh! undoubtedly," said Mr. Satterthwaite dryly.

The *séance* was held in the library. The hostess was, as Mr. Satterthwaite could see, very unwilling, only the obvious delight of her guests in the proceedings reconciled her to the ordeal.

The arrangements were made with a good deal of care by Mrs. Casson, who was evidently well up in those matters, the chairs were set round in a circle, the curtains were drawn, and presently the medium announced herself ready to begin.

"Six people," she said, looking round the room. "That is bad. We must have an uneven number, Seven is ideal. I get my best results out of a circle of seven."

"One of the servants," suggested Roley. He rose. "I will rout out the butler."

"Let's have Clayton," said Margery.

Mr. Satterthwaite saw a look of annoyance pass over Roley Vavasour's good-looking face.

"But why Clayton?" he demanded.

"You don't like Clayton," said Margery slowly.

Roley shrugged his shoulders. "Clayton doesn't like me," he said whimsically. "In fact she hates me like poison." He waited a minute or two, but Margery did not give way. "All right," he said, "have her down."

The circle was formed.

There was a period of silence broken by the usual coughs and fidgetings. Presently a succession of raps were heard and then the voice of the medium's control, a Red Indian called Cherokee.

"Indian Brave says you Good evening ladies and gentlemen. Someone here very anxious speak. Someone here very anxious give message to young lady. I go now. The spirit say what she come to say."

A pause and then a new voice, that of a woman, said softly:

"Is Margery here?"

Roley Vavasour took it upon himself to answer.

"Yes," he said, "she is. Who is that speaking?"

“I am Beatrice.”

“Beatrice? Who is Beatrice?”

To everyone’s annoyance the voice of the Red Indian Cherokee was heard once more.

“I have message for all of you people. Life here very bright and beautiful. We all work very hard. Help those who have not yet passed over.”

Again a silence and then the woman’s voice was heard once more.

“This is Beatrice speaking.”

“Beatrice who?”

“Beatrice Barron.”

Mr. Satterthwaite leaned forward. He was very excited.

“Beatrice Barron who was drowned in the ‘Uralia’?”

“Yes, that is right. I remember the ‘Uralia.’ I have a message—for this house—*Give back what is not yours.*”

“I don’t understand,” said Margery helplessly. “I—oh, are you really Aunt Beatrice?”

“Yes, I am your aunt.”

“Of course she is,” said Mrs. Casson reproachfully. “How can you be so suspicious? The spirits don’t like it.”

And suddenly Mr. Satterthwaite thought of a very simple test. His voice quivered as he spoke.

“Do you remember Mr. Bottacetti?” he asked.

Immediately there came a ripple of laughter.

“Poor old Boatsupsetty. Of course.”

Mr. Satterthwaite was dumbfounded. The test had succeeded. It was an incident of over forty years ago which had happened when he and the Barron girls had found themselves at the same seaside resort. A young Italian acquaintance of theirs had gone out in a boat and capsized, and Beatrice Barron had jestingly named him Boatsupsetty. It seemed impossible that anyone in the room could know of this incident except himself.

The medium stirred and groaned.

“She is coming out,” said Mrs. Casson. “That is all we will get out of her today, I am afraid.”

The daylight shone once more on the room full of people, two of whom at least were badly scared.

Mr. Satterthwaite saw by Margery's white face that she was deeply perturbed. When they had got rid of Mrs. Casson and the medium, he sought a private interview with his hostess.

"I want to ask you one or two questions, Miss Margery. If you and your mother were to die who succeeds to the title and estates?"

"Roley Vavasour, I suppose. His mother was Mother's first cousin."

Mr. Satterthwaite nodded.

"He seems to have been here a lot this winter," he said gently. "You will forgive me asking—but is he—fond of you?"

"He asked me to marry him three weeks ago," said Margery quietly. "I said No."

"Please forgive me, but are you engaged to anyone else?"

He saw the colour sweep over her face.

"I am," she said emphatically. "I am going to marry Noel Barton. Mother laughs and says it is absurd. She seems to think it is ridiculous to be engaged to a curate. Why, I should like to know! There are curates and curates! You should see Noel on a horse."

"Oh, quite so," said Mr. Satterthwaite. "Oh, undoubtedly."

A footman entered with a telegram on a salver. Margery tore it open. "Mother is arriving home tomorrow," she said. "Bother. I wish to goodness she would stay away."

Mr. Satterthwaite made no comment on this filial sentiment. Perhaps he thought it justified. "In that case," he murmured, "I think I am returning to London."

Mr. Satterthwaite was not quite pleased with himself. He felt that he had left this particular problem in an unfinished state. True that, on Lady Stranleigh's return, his responsibility was ended, yet he felt assured that he had not heard the last of the Abbot's Mede mystery.

But the next development when it came was so serious in its character that it found him totally unprepared. He learnt of it in the pages of his morning paper. "Baroness Dies in her Bath," as the *Daily Megaphone* had it. The other papers were more restrained and delicate in their language, but the fact was the same. Lady Stranleigh had been found dead in her bath and her death was due to drowning. She had, it was assumed, lost consciousness, and whilst in that state her head had slipped below the water.

But Mr. Satterthwaite was not satisfied with that explanation. Calling for his valet he made his toilet with less than his usual care, and ten minutes later his big Rolls-Royce was carrying him out of London as fast as it could travel.

But strangely enough it was not for Abbot's Mede he was bound, but for a small inn some fifteen miles distant which bore the rather unusual name of the "Bells and Motley." It was with great relief that he heard that Mr. Harley Quin was still staying there. In another minute he was face to face with his friend.

Mr. Satterthwaite clasped him by the hand and began to speak at once in an agitated manner.

"I am terribly upset. You must help me. Already I have a dreadful feeling that it may be too late—that that nice girl may be the next to go, for she is a nice girl, nice through and through."

"If you will tell me," said Mr. Quin, smiling, "what it is all about?"

Mr. Satterthwaite looked at him reproachfully.

"You know. I am perfectly certain that you know. But I will tell you."

He poured out the story of his stay at Abbot's Mede and, as always with Mr. Quin, he found himself taking pleasure in his narrative. He was eloquent and subtle and meticulous as to detail.

"So you see," he ended, "there must be an explanation."

He looked hopefully at Mr. Quin as a dog looks at his master.

"But it is you who must solve the problem, not I," said Mr. Quin. "I do not know these people. You do."

"I knew the Barron girls forty years ago," said Mr. Satterthwaite with pride.

Mr. Quin nodded and looked sympathetic, so much so that the other went on dreamily.

"That time at Brighton now, Bottacetti-Boatsupsetty, quite a silly joke but how we laughed. Dear, dear, I was young then. Did a lot of foolish things. I remember the maid they had with them. Alice, her name was, a little bit of a thing—very ingenuous. I kissed her in the passage of the hotel, I remember, and one of the girls nearly caught me doing it. Dear, dear, how long ago that all was."

He shook his head again and sighed. Then he looked at Mr. Quin.

"So you can't help me?" he said wistfully. "On other occasions—"

“On other occasions you have proved successful owing entirely to your own efforts,” said Mr. Quin gravely. “I think it will be the same this time. If I were you, I should go to Abbot’s Mede now.”

“Quite so, quite so,” said Mr. Satterthwaite, “as a matter of fact that is what I thought of doing. I can’t persuade you to come with me?”

Mr. Quin shook his head.

“No,” he said, “my work here is done. I am leaving almost immediately.”

At Abbot’s Mede, Mr. Satterthwaite was taken at once to Margery Gale. She was sitting dry-eyed at a desk in the morning room on which were strewn various papers. Something in her greeting touched him. She seemed so very pleased to see him.

“Roley and Maria have just left. Mr. Satterthwaite, it is not as the doctors think. I am convinced, absolutely convinced, that Mother was pushed under the water and held there. She was murdered, and whoever murdered her wants to murder me too. I am sure of that. That is why—” she indicated the document in front of her.

“I have been making my will,” she explained. “A lot of the money and some of the property does not go with the title, and there is my father’s money as well. I am leaving everything I can to Noel. I know he will make a good use of it and I do not trust Roley, he has always been out for what he can get. Will you sign it as a witness?”

“My dear young lady,” said Mr. Satterthwaite, “you should sign a will in the presence of two witnesses and they should then sign themselves at the same time.”

Margery brushed aside this legal pronouncement.

“I don’t see that it matters in the least,” she declared. “Clayton saw me sign and then she signed her name. I was going to ring for the butler, but you will do instead.”

Mr. Satterthwaite uttered no fresh protest, he unscrewed his fountain pen and then, as he was about to append his signature, he paused suddenly. The name, written just above his own, recalled a flow of memories. Alice Clayton.

Something seemed to be struggling very hard to get through to him. Alice Clayton, there was some significance about that. Something to do

with Mr. Quin was mixed up with it. Something he had said to Mr. Quin only a very short time ago.

Ah, he had it now. Alice Clayton, that was her name. *The little bit of a thing*. People changed—yes, *but not like that*. And the Alice Clayton he knew had had brown eyes. The room seemed whirling round him. He felt for a chair and presently, as though from a great distance, he heard Margery's voice speaking to him anxiously. "Are you ill? Oh, what is it? I am sure you are ill."

He was himself again. He took her hand.

"My dear, I see it all now. You must prepare yourself for a great shock. The woman upstairs whom you call Clayton is not Clayton at all. The real Alice Clayton was drowned on the 'Uralia.' "

Margery was staring at him. "Who—who is she then?"

"I am not mistaken, I cannot be mistaken. The woman you call Clayton is your mother's sister, Beatrice Barron. You remember telling me that she was struck on the head by a spar? I should imagine that that blow destroyed her memory, and that being the case, your mother saw the chance—"

"Of pinching the title, you mean?" asked Margery bitterly. "Yes, she would do that. It seems dreadful to say that now she is dead, but she was like that."

"Beatrice was the elder sister," said Mr. Satterthwaite. "By your uncle's death she would inherit everything and your mother would get nothing. Your mother claimed the wounded girl as her *maid*, not as her *sister*. The girl recovered from the blow and believed, of course, what was told her, that she was Alice Clayton, your mother's maid. I should imagine that just lately her memory had begun to return, but that the blow on the head, given all these years ago, has at last caused mischief on the brain."

Margery was looking at him with eyes of horror.

"She killed Mother and she wanted to kill me," she breathed.

"It seems so," said Mr. Satterthwaite. "In her brain there was just one muddled idea—that her inheritance had been stolen and was being kept from her by you and your mother."

"But—but Clayton is so old."

Mr. Satterthwaite was silent for a minute as a vision rose up before him—the faded old woman with grey hair, and the radiant golden-haired creature sitting in the sunshine at Cannes. Sisters! Could it really be so? He

remembered the Barron girls and their likeness to each other. Just because two lives had developed on different tracks—

He shook his head sharply, obsessed by the wonder and pity of life. . . .

He turned to Margery and said gently: “We had better go upstairs and see her.”

They found Clayton sitting in the little workroom where she sewed. She did not turn her head as they came in for a reason that Mr. Satterthwaite soon found out.

“Heart failure,” he murmured, as he touched the cold rigid shoulder. “Perhaps it is best that way.”

About the Author

AGATHA CHRISTIE is the most widely published author of all time, outsold only by the Bible and Shakespeare. Her books have sold more than a billion copies in English and another billion in a hundred foreign languages. She died in 1976.

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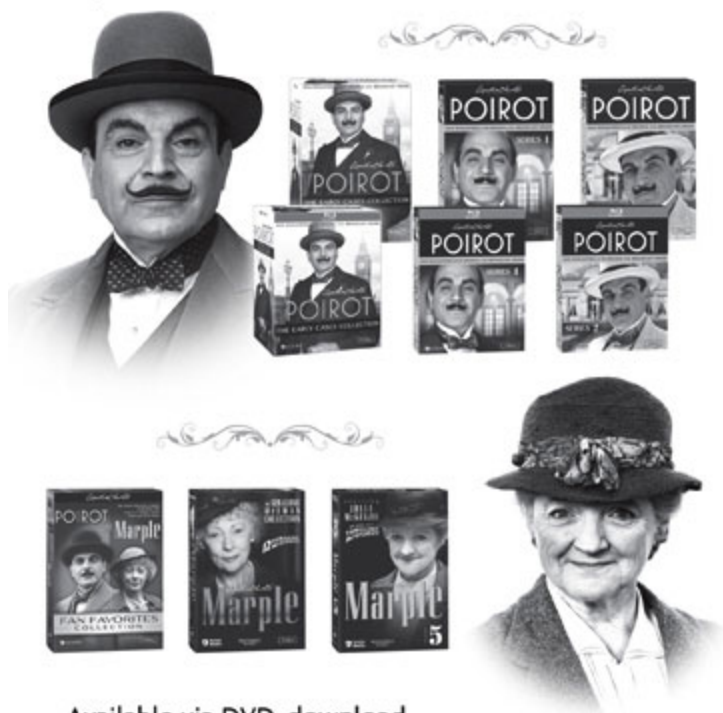
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